

Lesson 7: Owning Your Game

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Take a moment to stop and think. Is there any area this past month in which you've *haven't* been true to your authentic self at work? C'mon...you know what I'm talking about! That time when you knew a solution but didn't want to look rude. Maybe you downplayed a skill you have in order to fit in with the workgroup you were on. Or that time you know you should have spoken up in a meeting...but didn't and the opportunity passed.

Whatever it was, you didn't "own it."

It's OK – we all do this! We're wired to "fit in" and "go with the flow" and for women sometimes that means accidentally fitting into stereotypes other people have created for our gender.

But as strong, powerful women, we can't afford to think like this anymore. The workplace *needs* your contribution. I'll say it again – Your workplace needs *you*!

As with any team, the corporate workplace is filled with unique personalities. *No one* has it all – we fill in the gaps for each other and all work together towards a common goal.

There are several parts to "owning your own game," beginning with:

#1 – Knowing yourself. You've got to know your own strengths. What are you good at? What are you *great* at? What can you help your team or your leadership team with *right now*?

#2 – Knowing your brand. What image do you currently project, and what image do you want to project. What do you want people to think about when your name comes to mind? Reliable? Sharp? Focused? Collaborative? Innovative? You get the idea.

#3 – Knowing your boundaries. An important part of owning your game is knowing your boundaries at work. Where are you prepared to go beyond for the team, and where are areas you need to rein it in to guard your priorities?

Finally, knowing when to speak up. The art of knowing when to speak up and when to be silent is truly an art. And many women simply default to not speaking up in order to "maintain an even strain." This *doesn't* mean you need to speak up on or challenge everything. It means knowing the right time to weigh in, and not putting yourself on autopilot.

And it goes without saying that you want to be a "go-to player" in your field.

I actually know of a woman who was very quiet, very reserved, always sat in the back of the room, and she actually didn't do very well in her position. It was the moment she started to speak up. It was the moment that she stood up for herself, created her own boundaries, and stayed in her own lane. When you can stay in your own lane, there's no one else who can compete with you. She ended up being one of the top producers in our company once she broke her own mold.

We'll go over all of this in the upcoming lesson.